## Q What can I do to help ease the symptoms of cystic fibrosis?

**First and foremost make sure you get all the information and support that's available to you.** Then, follow the guidelines from your specialist carefully. These will be tailored to your child's individual requirements and can help you to manage her condition. Importantly, give your baby all her medicines, including any that help her to digest her food properly, since this is essential for growth and development. In consultation with your doctor, make sure she gets all her immunizations at the correct times, since she is especially susceptible to illness.

You will also have a physical therapist involved in your baby's care. He or she will teach you age-appropriate techniques that help clear the lungs, so that you can give your child essential care at home. Ask plenty of questions while you learn the techniques until you're fully confident about using the methods on your own. Try not to panic when your baby experiences breathing difficulties since she is more likely to be anxious if she senses that you are panicking, which can worsen her symptoms. Be reassuring and matter of fact while you carefully administer the procedures you've been taught. However, if at any point you are very concerned about your baby's breathing, call the hospital—or an ambulance.

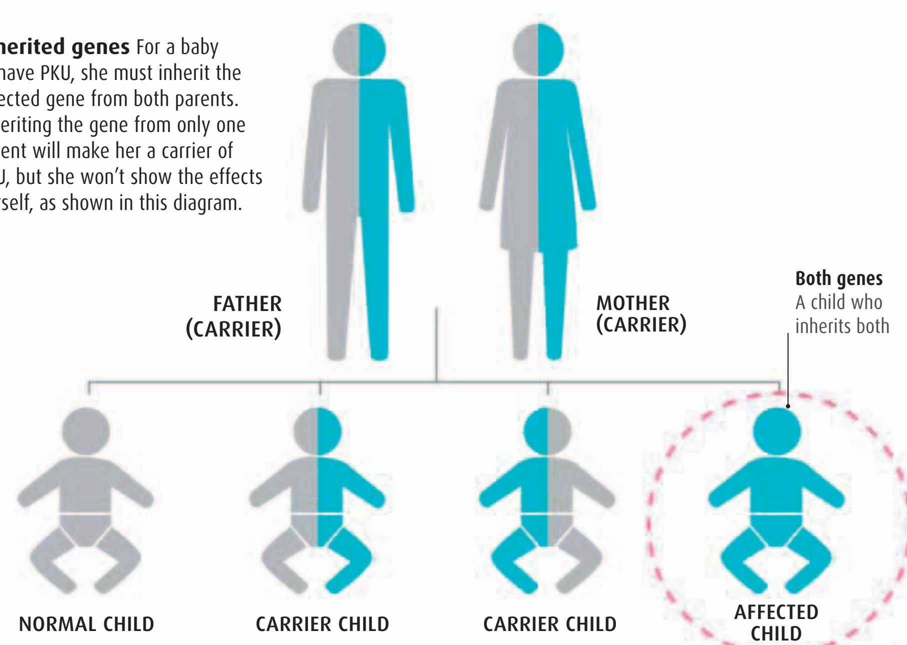
It's a good idea to extend your trusted network of friends or relatives who can use CF techniques so that you have support to call on when you need it.

## Q I've been told my baby has phenylketonuria. What is this?

**This rare genetic condition, referred to as PKU, occurs when the body lacks or is unable to make an enzyme called phenylalanine hydroxylase (PAH).**

The enzyme PAH is needed to convert the amino acid (the building blocks of protein) phenylalanine into another amino acid, tyrosine. Tyrosine helps regulate moods, aid concentration and memory, and maintain energy levels. A buildup of phenylalanine can lead to severe neurological damage. Although potentially serious, once detected, PKU is completely treatable with a special diet (including special infant milk), which needs to be maintained throughout life. The heel prick blood test (see p.250) done in the first week of life screens for PKU, and if your baby is found to have it, early treatment is given. The condition affects only one baby in every 15,000 born in the US each year.

**Inherited genes** For a baby to have PKU, she must inherit the affected gene from both parents. Inheriting the gene from only one parent will make her a carrier of PKU, but she won't show the effects herself, as shown in this diagram.




## Q I've been told CF may affect my baby's growth. How can I help her growth?

**In addition to giving your baby supplements to assist her digestion (see p.329) to make sure she absorbs essential nutrients, you'll probably need to start her on solid foods slightly earlier than is usually recommended—perhaps as early as three months old—to make sure she gets the calories she needs to grow properly.** As she gets older, keep plenty of high-calorie snacks in the home and encourage her to eat them regularly, as well as her usual meals. Also encourage your older child to take part in sports and other physical activities to help strengthen her lungs. It can seem counterintuitive, but exercise is an important part of her therapy. Not only that, but running, playing, and competing at sports with friends is essential for giving her as normal a life as possible.

## Q How does phenylketonuria (PKU) affect babies?

**A baby who inherits PKU may begin to show symptoms in the first few months of life if the condition goes undetected.** Symptoms include convulsions, a musty odor on her skin or in her urine, a pale complexion and eye color, slow growth rate, a small head, and eczema. In time, if PKU goes untreated, children may develop severe learning and behavioral problems, and hyperactivity.

## Q Will my baby develop healthily, even though she has PKU?

**As long as you adhere to her dietary regimen (and she continues to follow it when she's older), evidence suggests that PKU has no obvious effects on growth, emotional and social development, or mental agility.** A PKU diet is low in protein and includes some carbohydrates, as well as supplements of the amino acid tyrosine that supports certain brain functions (see box, left). Your baby will have regular blood tests during childhood to monitor the levels of phenylalanine in her blood to ensure they are within safe limits.